

NCAA Tackles Decline in Sports Referees with New Initiatives

By Caleb Evans

During the 1971 Ohio State-Michigan game, one of the most notable football referees, Jerry Markbreit, remembers being berated by legendary Ohio State coach Woody Hayes for a pass interference non-call that wasn't even his to make. Markbreit displayed a poised demeanor that made him the great referee he was.

"I was afraid of nobody," said Markbreit. "I felt so powerful out there."

In a college sports landscape dominated by NIL debates, transfer portal chaos, and media rights wars, one quieter but essential concern continues to loom: the sustainability of the officiating workforce. In March, the NCAA took a strategic step to address that issue with the launch of the Player-to-Ref initiative, a fast-track program aimed at transitioning recently graduated college athletes into officiating roles.

Originally piloted in Division II, the program officially rolled out across NCAA divisions in March, and it's already drawing interest. Since its launch, 110 former athletes have expressed interest, offering hope that those who've lived the game can now help manage it from a new perspective.

While much has been made about a nationwide shortage of referees, those close to the issue don't see a crisis, at least not in terms of numbers. Ben Brownlee, the Associate Director of Officiating at the NCAA, said there are currently nearly 30,000 registered college officials across 15 major sports, compared to about 15,000 across 13 sports just a few years ago.

However, the biggest challenge isn't volume, it's retention and readiness.

A 2021 study conducted by the National Association of Sports Officials found that the number one reason college referees quit is poor treatment from fans, players, and coaches alike. The findings revealed that emotional burnout caused by verbal abuse and lack of respect far outweighed factors like pay or workload.

“Imagine you're a Division II or Division III ref and there are 100 fans in a 500-seat gym at a D-III school or you're in a 2000-seat arena and you can hear every word that's yelled at you,” Brownlee said. “It takes a special person to handle that.”

That's where the Player-to-Ref initiative comes in. By recruiting former athletes, people who already understand the mental toughness and tempo of college sports, the NCAA hopes to bolster officiating with individuals who bring game IQ and thick skin to the role.

“We've been thrilled by the early response,” said Penny Davis, the NCAA's National Coordinator of Women's Basketball Officiating. “There's a unique advantage to recruiting people who've already played the game. They have the instincts, the game sense, and the credibility.”

Beyond game knowledge, the initiative also aims to better represent the athletes on the field. With the rise of sports like women's wrestling, acrobatics and tumbling, and beach volleyball, the NCAA is now faced with training referees for fast-growing, often underserved sports, and ensuring those refs reflect the gender and racial diversity of the athletes they're officiating.

“We want the athletes to see themselves in the officials,” Davis added. “Representation is just as important in stripes as it is in uniforms.”

The NCAA is also turning to Ref Reps to be the primary provider for the college officiating curriculum. Ref Reps offers foundational training, video simulations, and certification pathways for officials across sports. Alongside that, platforms like RQ+ help deepen development through film breakdowns, rules education, and mentorship from veteran officials.

Traditionally, becoming a college ref meant grinding through years of youth or high school games. But the NCAA sees an opportunity in allowing former players to skip the bottom rung and quickly contribute in meaningful ways.

“There’s still a process,” Davis said. “But if you’ve played four years of college ball, you don’t need to start from scratch. You need tools, structure, and support.”

Still, real progress depends on changing the environment officials work in. Advocates say sports leaders, from athletic directors to broadcasters, must be more intentional in educating the public about what officials do and the abuse they often face.

“Officiating isn’t just for those who didn’t make it as players,” said Steve Shaw, National Coordinator of Football Officiating. “It’s a profession that requires expertise, composure, and leadership.”

By offering structured pathways, highlighting former athlete role models, and increasing institutional support, the NCAA is hoping to reframe officiating as a valuable and viable next step in the sports world.

To further solidify this pathway, the NCAA has expanded its partnership with the National Federation of State High School Associations (NFHS), the governing body for high school sports in the United States. The collaboration is centered around strengthening the pipeline from high

school officiating to the collegiate ranks, with the belief that investing at the foundational level will pay dividends at the top.

Brownlee, who has helped spearhead the NCAA's officiating outreach, put the goal into perspective.

“So, to go back to *The Lorax*, we’re gonna take maybe 10 officials out of the state of California, and we want to give you 40,” Brownlee said.